Scenario Analysis: Yemen at a Crossroads

Jiri Benes

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1 Introduction

Although Yemen ranks among the lowest-performing economies, its crude oil (OIL) and natural gas (NATGAS) resources attract the attention not only of regional powers. Moreover, its strategic geographic location affects international maritime shipping through the Strait of Aden. Recent political developments have been shaped by an ongoing civil war since 2012.

As of March 2026, the conflict has evolved into a stalemate between two prevailing factions: the Shia Houthi movement (Houthis), historically supported by Iran (IRN), which controls the northwest regions and encompasses nearly two-thirds of the country's population, and internationally recognised, predominantly Sunni Presidential Leadership Council (PLC), backed by Saudi Arabia (SAU), which controls southern and southeast regions, including the strategically important port of Aden and the majority of OIL and NATGAS fields. Currently, the Yemen is at a crossroads with several possible courses of action.

1.1 Factors

Factors were identified through initial PMEAII-PT analysis. As a result, these factors were shaped by constants which were assumed to remain stable, albeit with a significant impact on the region. The constants were identified as climate change, rapid demographic growth[1], and tribal/ethnic diversity. For the execution of scenario modelling were selected and elaborated following factors with direct implications to radicalization, extremism and terrorism (RET):

Macro – Political Situation

The first factor, defined by a military stalemate and a fragmented authority, was elaborated into two factors. While the first, Houthi consolidation into a recognised political force in NW Yemen, can create a sectarian grievance gap and forecast a surge of the Sunni militant groups as a protective shield, the other outcome – a negotiated settlement can eventually create pockets of radicalisation of not fully integrated tribal militias in remote rural areas with limited control due to insufficient infrastructure.

Micro – Political Situation

The second factor emphasises intra-state dynamics among a highly fragmented, tribally oriented Yemen society. As such, the first outcome leads to tribal cohesion and mediation between state authorities, characterised by reduced sectarian salience, whereas the second outcome, tribal fragmentation, evolves into exploitation by self-proclaimed tribal defenders attempting to intimidate national forces and therefore challenge their legitimacy.[2]

Resource Management

The third factor addresses the ability to ensure the supply of basic goods to a growing population in densely populated areas considering demographic and climate pressures. The first outcome implies systemic failure, which inevitably results into the weaponisation of basic services and the vulnerability of the population to extremist recruitment through deprivation. The second outcome

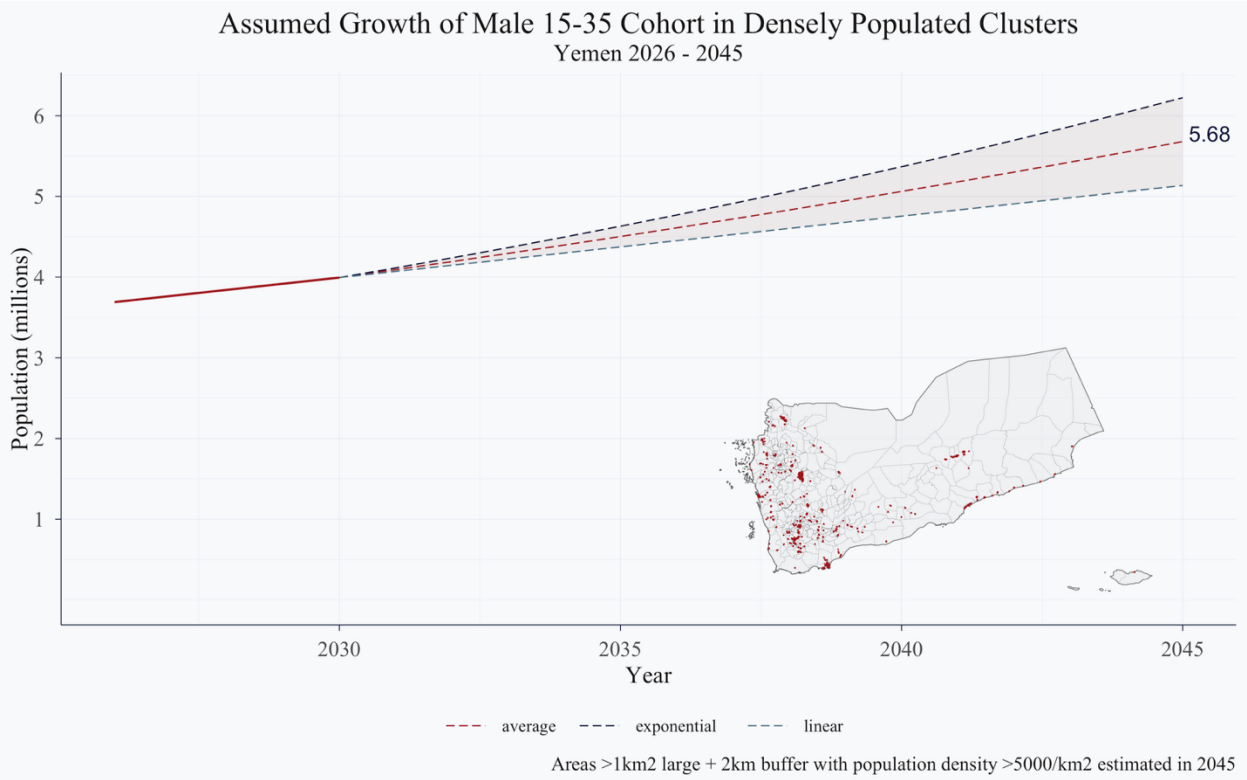
[1] Estimated demography was assessed through linear (civil unrest limiting exponential growth) and exponential model (peace allowing population to thrive) and their average.
[2] Terrorism maximising temporary political gains and practices of TG groups by Kydd and Walter (2006)

promises integrated resilience and a shift towards a decentralised, sustainable resource model, which mitigates grievances and prevents internal displacement.

Urban Youth Male Employability.

According to demographic model, the fourth factor elaborates on the capacity of Yemen to absorb rapidly growing young male population (FAM) which in 2045 should raise to 7.9 million in urban clusters (Figure 1) [3] and convert it into productive economic roles. The first outcome, high male unemployment, creates a recruitment pool of economically frustrated individuals who are exploited by extremist groups, whilst the second outcome, low male unemployment increases the cost of loss[4] in joining the opportunity group[5].

Figure 1 Assumed growth of population in densely populated clusters from 2030 to 2045



[3] Unemployment od fighting age male cohort has been assessed as a determining factor in terms of radicalisation and involvement in radicalised group. (Krieger and Meierrieks, D., 2019)
[4] According to the Rational Choice Theory
[5] According to (Kydd and Walter, 2006)

2 Analysis

According to the expert poll which evaluated compatibility of scenarios (see Table 1) there were three plausible courses of action selected for further examination according to the severity of consequences and plausibility.

Table 1 Batelle Scenario Analysis Compatibility Table

Macro-Polit. Sit.	Micro-Pol. Sit.	Resource Mngm.	Urban FAM* Employability	Scores	Worst Value	Average Value
Negotiated Settlement	Tribal Cohesion	Resource Adaptation	Low Male Unemployment	4;4;3;4;3;4	3.00	3.67
Houthis Consolidation	Tribal Fragmentation	Resource Collapse	High Male Unemployment	3;3;3;4;4;4	3.00	3.50
Houthis Consolidation	Tribal Cohesion	Resource Adaptation	Low Male Unemployment	2;3;3;4;3;4	2.00	3.17
Negotiated Settlement	Tribal Cohesion	Resource Adaptation	High Male Unemployment	4;4;2;4;3;2	2.00	3.17
Houthis Consolidation	Tribal Fragmentation	Resource Collapse	Low Male Unemployment	3;3;3;4;3;2	2.00	3.00
Houthis Consolidation	Tribal Fragmentation	Resource Adaptation	Low Male Unemployment	3;3;3;2;3;4	2.00	3.00
Negotiated Settlement	Tribal Fragmentation	Resource Collapse	High Male Unemployment	2;2;2;4;4;4	2.00	3.00
Negotiated Settlement	Tribal Fragmentation	Resource Adaptation	Low Male Unemployment	2;4;3;2;3;4	2.00	3.00
Houthis Consolidation	Tribal Cohesion	Resource Collapse	High Male Unemployment	2;3;3;2;3;4	2.00	2.83
Houthis Consolidation	Tribal Cohesion	Resource Adaptation	High Male Unemployment	2;3;3;4;3;2	2.00	2.83
Houthis Consolidation	Tribal Fragmentation	Resource Adaptation	High Male Unemployment	3;3;3;2;4;2	2.00	2.83
Negotiated Settlement	Tribal Cohesion	Resource Collapse	High Male Unemployment	4;2;2;2;3;4	2.00	2.83
Negotiated Settlement	Tribal Cohesion	Resource Collapse	Low Male Unemployment	4;2;3;2;3;2	2.00	2.67
Negotiated Settlement	Tribal Fragmentation	Resource Collapse	Low Male Unemployment	2;2;3;4;3;2	2.00	2.67
Negotiated Settlement	Tribal Fragmentation	Resource Adaptation	High Male Unemployment	2;4;2;2;4;2	2.00	2.67
Houthis Consolidation	Tribal Cohesion	Resource Collapse	Low Male Unemployment	2;3;3;2;3;2	2.00	2.50

*FAM = fighting age male, cohort Male15-45

First, the scenario 1 (Negotiated Settlement, Tribal Cohesion, Resource Adaptation and Low Male Unemployment) as a best possible course of action in the following 20 years. The second compatible course of action was the scenario 2 (Houthis Consolidation, Tribal Fragmentation, Resource Collapse and High Male Unemployment) as the worst possible scenario and the plausible scenario 4 (Negotiated Settlement, Tribal Cohesion, Resource Adaptation, High Male Unemployment). The second and third scenarios were selected for elaboration in terms of RET and for the tailoring of CT measures.

2.1 Scenario 2 –The Worst Course of Action

In Scenario 4, Houthis consolidate their political power over the NW part of Yemen controlling two thirds of the entire Yemen population. The rest of the country is ruled by the internationally recognised government, controlling the strategic port of Aden, OIL and NATGAS fields providing them with financial support as well as crucial alliances with the Gulf Countries. Salaries of exhausted and poorly trained security personnel are remaining low and their ability to deliver state power through military means shrinks to securing their own survival.

The fact that both state entities cannot efficiently control the country due to the lack of infrastructure and the mountainous geographical character, which provides good cover and concealment, creates a fertile ground for the flourishing of groups acting as security and the rule of law providers for a fragmented, disenfranchised, and state-abandoned tribal population. Moreover, both Houthi and PLC state entities are unable to provide the population with basic supply and welfare, which, together with the loss of sufficient opportunities to gain self-significance and improve living standards, lowers the cost for the FAM cohort of actively participating in political violence and illicit activities.

The extremist groups and identity militias are actively exploiting the power vacuum and the aggravated population, controlling resources and providing basic services, actively contributing to us-vs-them logic and organizationally thriving on successful recruitment attempting to intimidate other competing groups. The vast recruitment pool and no improvement in terms of the capacity of both governments to effectively counter these threats and maintain order in remote regions will seriously imply very limited CT capabilities mostly provided by foreign actors. Optional targeted strikes, conducted mostly through international assets, will focus mostly on the top strategic/operational echelon of alleged terrorist groups which may lead to the emergence of younger but potentially more radical leadership. (Bacon and Arsenault, 2019) Imprecise operations conducted by poorly trained state units may further detrimentally affect the trust in central governments which will have to disclose opportunistic alliances with tribal leadership and therefore silently fund ongoing terrorism and insurgency.

2.2 Scenario 4 – The Plausible Optimistic Course of Action

In Scenario 4, Houthis negotiate a settlement with the internationally recognised government which results into the consolidation of power and the transformation of the significant majority of Houthis into a political force participating in political competition. Parts of aggravated tribally affiliated factions do not support national reconciliation but are not a major political force. Tribal identity militias, Houthi military and PLC military are integrated into the national armed forces, supported and trained by foreign military support. A few radicals reject outside mediation and are unsuccessfully integrated through DDR process. Former militia/military members from both sides together with former aggravated leaders create the core of armed opposition, finding refuge in remote rural areas. These groups rely on indirect forms of violence rather than direct confrontation, harassing local authorities to provoke overreaction and delegitimize the government.[6]

The national government with significant regional and international aid can mitigate the impact of climate change and an exponentially growing population and manages to establish a sustainable agricultural model, which saturates the population with basic welfare. Involvement of law enforcement and military in the most vulnerable areas minimises exploitation of resources by armed groups. The success, however, accelerates urbanisation and creates Yemen as an attractive destination for regional migration from SOM and ETH. Due to migration, exponential population growth and unemployment within the FAM cohort, the main population clusters and slums creates pool for radicalization and fertile ground for group mobilisation. Disproportional responses of state forces occasionally escalate protests into violent riots.

CT policies primarily focus on disrupting links to international terrorism, particularly those proliferating from Africa, and on conducting selective targeted strikes against leadership and key operational actors across operational and strategic level, using lethal but also non-lethal means with questionable results. (Jordan, 2014) International help is focused mostly on intelligence capability building and advanced training in purchased advanced technologies, primarily in regions with foreign presence.

[6] Referring to one possible terrorist group's strategy according to Kydd and Walter (2005)

3 Policy Recommendation

The policy recommendation is grounded in Scenario 2. For Scenario 1 the policy would be significantly limited by the premises of a failing state pursuing its own survival at all costs.

The effective policy which incorporates necessary international aid, deliberate targeted strikes (lethal/non-lethal) on strategic/operational and tactical level, actionable policies enabling security forces to act (see Part 2), and policies delegitimizing and countering recruitment, should stem from a clearly stated objectives. In case of Scenario 2, such objectives should be the elimination of connecting links from Yemen to international terrorist groups by targeting financial streams and knowledge exchange. According to the reconciliation process the remote areas should be controlled by respected tribal entities which should be equipped with limited executive powers. (Kydd and Walter, 2006)

On the operational level, the policy should thoughtfully analyse the trade-offs of lethal targeted strikes on the top echelon of insurgency (Jordan, 2014; 2020; Schwartz et al, 2022). Such constraints might be closely linked to the later absence of counterparts for negotiations and the spread of limitless violence of newly emerged leaders. Further effort should be invested in the delegitimization of terrorists[7] through alternating narratives collaboratively with raising the costs of engagement in violent activities.

The international military aid should focus on the development of principles of military effectiveness (Talmadge, 2015) rather than “hard skills”, therefore the Yemeni security forces may be able to independently execute intelligence driven operations with limited collateral damage across all levels. Finally, the NATO forces should maintain absolute control over highly effective and advanced autonomous weapon systems.

Finally, the success of the policy is inherently linked to the development of precise metrics through which these policies can be evaluated. (Bakas, 2020)

[7] Klein (2015) on recruitment in domestic terrorism and trade-offs, example Iraq which have similar populational distribution (Shia X Sunni)

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